

Make Your Comment Count

A public comment action sheet from Chapter 13 of Wildlife Conservation for Everyday People

THE ONE THING TO KNOW

When a federal agency proposes a rule, it must read and respond to every substantive comment. "I oppose this rule" contributes nothing legally. A comment that names a factual error, brings data, or cites a source creates a record the agency must address.

One specific, cited comment does real work. A thousand signatures do not.

FIVE STEPS TO A COMMENT THAT COUNTS

1. Find an open comment period.

Set a Federal Register alert for one species or habitat (federalregister.gov). Watch the Center for Biological Diversity newsletter for deadlines.

2. Read the proposal.

What does the rule do? What is the agency's stated rationale? You cannot counter what you have not read.

3. Find your angle.

A factual error. Missing data. Your own field experience. A legal gap the agency ignored. That is your hook.

4. Write it substantive.

Be specific. Cite at least one source. Plain, clear language. No law degree required.

5. Submit before the deadline.

File at regulations.gov (search by docket number). Keep a copy of everything you send.

DON'T FORGET YOUR COUNTY

Local land use is decided by people who face re-election. Get on your county planning commission's agenda list. Show up when development near corridors, wetlands, or floodplains is reviewed. Ask for the environmental assessment. If one was required and wasn't done, say so on the record.

My commitment: one substantive comment this year on _____



Thicket & Bone
Coexistence today for a wild tomorrow.



Your Comment Template

Fill this in, then file it at [regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov) before the deadline.

RE: DOCKET NUMBER

THE PROPOSED RULE, IN ONE SENTENCE

WHO I AM (NAME, AND WHY THIS MATTERS TO YOU)

WHAT THE RULE GETS WRONG (BE SPECIFIC)

MY EVIDENCE (CITE AT LEAST ONE SOURCE)

WHAT I AM ASKING THE AGENCY TO DO

BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

☐ Specific, not just "I oppose this"

☐ Cited at least one source

☐ Filed before the deadline

☐ Kept a copy of what I sent